

Session 24: The Lion of Judah

Key Takeaways

- The New Testament authors reveal that the royal lion of Yehudah is also the sacrificial lamb that was slain, portraying Jesus' death and resurrection as the fulfillment of Yehudah's royal exaltation.
- The royal rod (or scepter) of Yehudah can represent either punishment or rule. Later biblical authors will interpret this promise to Yehudah as both judgment and blessing.
- The final section of the blessing of Yehudah looks forward to Eden abundance under the rule of the promised king.

The Royal Blessing on Yehudah

³ **Reuven**, you are my first-born,
my strength and the beginning of my vigor.

Excelling in dignity,
and **excelling** in **strength**
⁴ uncontrollable like water,
you will **not excel** !

a' Because **you went up** (עלית) on **the bed** of your father
b then you profaned **my couch** —
a' to **my couch** **he went up**!

⁵ **Shim'on and Levi**, brothers;
their schemes are weapons of violence.

⁶ Into their council may my life not enter,
to their assembly may my honor never be joined;
Because in **their anger** they murdered men,
and in **their pleasure** they hamstrung oxen.

⁷ Cursed be **their anger** for it is **strong**
and **their wrath**, because it is harsh.

I will divide them up among Ya'akov,

and I will scatter them among Yisra'el.

- a 8 **Yehudah**, as for you, **your brothers will praise you** (יִדּוּד).
b Your hand (יָד) will be on the neck of your enemies (אֹיִבִּים),
a' the **sons of your father** (אֲבִיךָ) **will bow down to you**.
a 9 A **cub of a lion** is Yehudah
b from the prey, my son, **you have gone up** (עָלִיתָ).
a' He crouches, he lies down, like a **lion**,
b' and like a **young lion**, **who will make him rise up**?

10 **The scepter** will not depart from Yehudah
nor **the ruler's staff** from between his feet,
unto when he comes to whom it belongs,
and the obedience of the peoples will belong to him.

11 Binding **his donkey to the vine**,
and **a son of his mare to the offshoot**,
he washes his clothing in **wine**,
and his robe **in the blood of grapes**.
12 Eyes sparkle from **wine**,
and teeth white from **milk**!

Genesis 49:3-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

This blessing on Yehudah is one of the high points of the Genesis scroll, and it develops the theme of the coming seed of the woman (from Gen. 3:15) in ways that echo throughout the rest of the Bible.

Yehudah as a New Yoseph Among the Brothers

Here Yehudah is named the leader among the brothers, and his role in the family is described with precisely the same language used in the blessing that Yaaqov received from Isaac (Gen. 27:29) and in the language used throughout Yoseph's story about his elevation to a place of rule among the brothers.

The Blessing Isaac Gave to Yaaqov in Genesis 27:29

Peoples will serve you
and **people groups will bow down to you**,
you will be mighty for your brothers
and **the sons of your mother will bow down to you**

Yaaqov's Blessing for Yehudah in Genesis 49:8-12

Yehudah, as for you, **your brothers** will praise you;
your hand will be on the neck of your enemies

Blessings for Jacob and Judah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

the sons of your father will bow down to you.

...

The scepter will not depart from Yehudah
nor the ruler's staff from between his feet,
unto when he comes to whom it belongs,
and the obedience of the peoples will belong to him.

Yoseph and His Brothers in Genesis 37:10 and 42:6

Gen. 37:10 Am **I and your mother and your brothers**
to **bow down to you** on the ground?

Gen. 42:6 And **the brothers** of Yoseph came
and **they bowed down to him**, faces on the ground.

Blessings for Jacob and Judah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

The blessing of Yehudah says in no uncertain terms that a future seed will arise from his lineage and that ruler will receive the homage of the tribes of Israel and of the nations when he comes into his rule. And that homage is described in the language of the narrative about Yoseph and his brothers. In other words, the story of Yoseph's rise to a place of rule among his brothers is here turned into a narrative analogy that is applied to the future rule of the seed of Yehudah. This poem shows how the author of Genesis wants us to read the Yoseph story through a messianic lens as a story that points forward to another future ruler from the tribe of Yehudah who will arise to rescue the tribes of Israel and the nations.

Now it is clear why the stories of David and Solomon, descendants from Yehudah, echo so powerfully in the Prophets and Psalms and are always being connected back to this promise and the imagery of the story of Yoseph.

- [Isaiah 2:1-4, 11:1-12, 49:1-8, 52:13-53:12, 61:1-10](#)
- [Ezekiel 34, 36-37](#)
- [Hosea 3](#)
- [Amos 9:11-15](#)
- [Micah 4:1-6, 5:1-10](#)
- [Psalms 2, 20-22, 72, 89, 110, 132](#)
- Etc.

"Unlike the imagery used of the other sons, the words of Jacob regarding Judah are quite transparent, though they are, of course, made up of poetic images. Judah is described as a victorious warrior who returns home from battle and is greeted by the shouts of praise from his brothers. The parallelism ... is extended by the statement, 'Your father's sons will bow down to you.' It is difficult not to see in this statement an intentional allusion to the dream of Joseph ([37:10](#)) in which his father's sons would come to bow down before him. In other words, what Joseph's dreams predicted and then did happen in the course of the narrative (e.g., [42:6](#)), these stories are here being transferred to the future of the house of Judah.

That which happened to Joseph is portrayed as a picture of that which would happen to Judah 'in the last days' (49:1)."

Sailhamer, John H. (1995). [*The Pentateuch as Narrative: A Biblical-Theological Commentary*](#). Zondervan Academic. 235.

"In this blessing Jacob depicts the coming Judahite with imagery that closely resembles the life of Joseph. ... Indeed, the image of eleven brothers 'bowing' to their royal sibling in Genesis 49:8 reads like a summary of the preceding Joseph story. This similarity is deliberate. Joseph is a 'narrative prefiguration' of Judah's seed ... the life of the future royal seed of Judah is patterned on the life of Joseph. Joseph is the type of king Israel will see again. ... In short, Jacob's prophecy is the most explicit evidence from Genesis that Joseph's character functions typologically, his life is a pattern of things to come."

Emadi, Samuel (2018). [*"Covenant, Typology, and the Story of Joseph"*](#). Tyndale Bulletin, Volume 69.1. 79-81.

The later David narratives explicitly portray him according to the pattern of Yoseph.

- Both are shepherds: [1 Samuel 16:11, 19](#) // [Genesis 37:2](#)
- Both selected over their brothers to a place of royal rule: [1 Samuel 16:6-13](#) // [Genesis 37:5-11](#)
- Both were sent to assuage the troubled king of his "bad spirit": [1 Sam. 16:16-18](#) // [Genesis 41](#) and Pharaoh's dreams.
- Both were sent by their fathers to inquire about the shalom of their brothers: [1 Samuel 17:17-18](#) // [Genesis 37:13-14](#); in both stories the brothers are hostile: [1 Samuel 17:28](#) // [Genesis 37:18-28](#).
- Both predict that a foreign leader will have their "head lifted off" (Goliath in [1 Sam. 17:46](#) // the Egyptian baker in [Gen. 40:19](#)).
- Both are endowed with "understanding" (נבון, [Gen. 41:33, 39](#) // [1 Sam. 16:18](#)) by the Spirit of God (רוח אלהים, [Gen. 41:38](#) // [1 Sam. 16:13](#)) and "beautiful of appearance" (יפה מראה, [Gen. 39:6](#) // [1 Sam. 16:12](#) and [17:42](#)) and "a man of form" ([1 Sam. 16:18](#), איש תאר // "beautiful of form" [Gen. 39:6](#), יפה תאר).
- Both are elevated by officials and kings who "set them over" responsibility: Yoseph is "appointed over" (פקד + על) the house of Potiphar ([Gen. 39:4](#)) // David, who is "set over" (שים + על) the army ([1 Sam. 18:5](#)).
- "And Yahweh was/is with him" ([1 Sam. 16:18, 17:37, 18:12, 28](#) // [Gen. 39:2, 21](#)).
- Both are "clothed" (לבש) with royal garments by a king in their exaltation story ([1 Sam. 17:38](#) // [Gen. 41:42](#)).
- David is sent to Saul with a "young goat" ([1 Sam. 16:20](#), גדי עזים), while Yoseph is replaced by his brothers with a "male goat" (שעיר עזים) to trick Yaaqov ([Gen. 37:31](#)).
- David the last-born is loved by Saul ([1 Sam 16:21](#), אהב), while Yoseph the 11th-born is loved by Yaaqov ([Gen. 37:4](#)).
- David "finds favor in the eyes of Saul" ([1 Sam. 16:22](#)). // Yoseph find favor in the eyes of Potiphar ([Gen. 39:4](#)) and the prison officer ([Gen. 39:21](#)).
- Jonathan son of Saul, of Binyamin brother of Yoseph "loves" (אהב) David of Yehudah, brother of Yoseph, and "his life is bound to David's life" ([1 Sam. 18:1](#), נפש יהונתן נקשרה בנפש דוד, // Yehudah appeals to Yoseph concerning his brother Binyamin, saying that Yaaqov "loves" (אהב, [Gen. 44:20](#)) him and that "his life is bound to his life" (נפשו קשורה בנפשו, [Gen. 44:30](#)).
- Yoseph's brothers, including Yehudah, "strip him" (פשט) of his royal garment ([Gen. 37:23](#)), // Jonathan of Binyamin brother of Yoseph "strips off" (פשט) his royal garment and gives it to David of Yehudah ([1 Sam. 18:4](#)).

- The scene of Jonathan (son of Binyamin) parting with David (son of Yehudah) is modeled after the reunion scene of Yoseph and Yehudah and Binyamin, along with all the rest of the brothers.
1. "And [David] fell on his face on the ground and he bowed" (1 Sam. 20:41) // "and [the brothers] bowed down on the ground" (Gen. 43:26) + "and they fell on their faces on the ground" (Gen. 44:14).
 2. "And they kissed each his other and they wept" (1 Sam. 20:41) // "and he fell upon the neck of Binyamin his brother and he wept ... and he kissed all his brothers and he wept over them" (Gen. 45:14-15).

Early Jewish Interpretation of Genesis 49:8-10

"8. Judah, you will your brothers praise, and by your name shall all the Jews be called Jews. Your hands will avenge you of your enemies; all the sons of your father shall advance to salute you. 9. I shall compare you, Judah, to a lion's whelp; you saved my son Joseph from his murderers. From the judgment of Tamar, my son, you are innocent; you will rest and dwell in the midst of battle, like the lion and like the lioness, and there is no nation nor kingdom that shall stand against you. 10. Kings shall not cease from among those of the house of Judah and neither (shall) scribes teaching the Law from his son's sons unto the time King Messiah shall come, to whom the kingship belongs; to him shall all the kingdoms be subject. 11. How beautiful is King Messiah who is to arise from among those of the house of Judah. He girds his loins and goes forth to battle against those that hate him; and he kills kings with rulers, and makes the mountains red from the blood of their slain and makes the valleys white from the fat of their warriors. His garments are rolled in blood; he is like a presser of grapes. 12. How beautiful are the eyes of King Messiah; more than pure wine, lest he see with them the revealing of nakedness or the shedding of innocent blood. His teeth are purer than milk, lest he eat with them things that are stolen or robbed. The mountains will become red from his vines and the vats from wine; and the hills will become white from the abundance of grain and flocks of sheep."

McNamara, Martin, translator (1991). [*Targum Neofiti 1: Genesis \(The Aramaic Bible\)*](#). Liturgical Press.

"8. Judah, you confessed and were not embarrassed; {therefore} your brothers shall praise you. Your hand shall prevail against your adversaries; your enemies shall be shattered; they shall turn their nape from you. Your father's sons shall come before you and salute you. 9. From the house of Judah dominion shall emerge in the beginning and a king shall be raised in the end; because you, my son, withdrew yourself from the sentence of death. He shall rest and dwell with strength like a lion and like a lioness, and there is no kingdom that could move him. 10. The ruler shall never depart from the House of Judah, nor the scribe from his children's children for evermore, unto when the Messiah comes, to whom belongs the kingdom, and him shall nations obey. 11. He shall lead Israel round about his city; the people shall build his Temple; the righteous shall be round about him; and they that carry out the Law shall be with him in study. Let his raiment, be of fine purple, and his garment all woolen, crimson, and of bright sparkling colors. 12. His mountains shall be red with his vineyards; his vats shall be dripping with wine; his valleys shall be white with grain and with flocks of sheep."

Grossfield, Bernard, translator (1988). [*The Targum Onqelos to Genesis \(The Aramaic Bible\)*](#). Liturgical Press.

"Rulers shall not cease from the house of Judah, nor teachers of the law from his posterity, until his descendant Messiah come, and the obedience of all peoples be unto him. How glorious is Messiah of the House of Judah! His loins girded, he will go out to do battle with his enemies. No king and no ruler will prevail against him. The mountains will be dyed red with their blood, and the garments of Messiah will be

like the garments of him that presseth wine. The eyes of Messiah will be clearer than pure wine, for they will never behold unchastity and bloodshed; and his teeth will be whiter than milk, for never will they bite aught that is taken by violence."

Ginzberg, Louis (2003). [*Legends of the Jews \(2nd ed.\)*](#). Jewish Publication Society. 408.

The Royal Rod of Yehudah

The phrase "lion of the tribe of Yehudah" that is found in the New Testament ([Rev. 5:5](#)) comes from this series of poetic images that describe Yehudah as a victor in battle. Notice the important density of royal vocabulary used in [Genesis 49:10](#).

Rod/Scepter

The Hebrew word *shevet* (שבט) means literally, "a wooden staff or rod."

The basic meaning of *shevet* is a wooden stick that symbolizes authority.

- It can mean "one who holds the *shevet*" ([Amos 1:5](#)).
- *Shevet* can also refer to a royal rod used to bring justice, so it is often used to describe a king "smashing with the rod," that is, attacking with an army (see [Isa. 10:15](#), [11:4](#), [28:27](#); [Micah 4:4](#)).
- Connected to the above, the word "rod" can refer simply to punishment (see [Isa. 11:4](#); [Job 37:13](#); [Ps. 89:32](#); [Prov. 13:24](#), [26:3](#), [29:15](#)).
- It can also refer to a shepherd's staff ([Micah 7:14](#); [Ps. 23:4](#)). But because "shepherd" is a common biblical metaphor for "king," these uses often have royal associations as well ([Ezek. 20:37](#)).

Ruler's Staff

The Hebrew word *mekhoqeq* (מחקק) means literally, "one who makes decrees and decisions."

The basic meaning of *mekhoqeq* is a person who carves decrees into stone to enact a decree for a group of people. It's a way to describe a ruler or leader in terms of their role in establishing order by way of legislation.

- The word refers to a person who makes decrees ([Judg. 5:14](#); [Isa. 33:22](#)).
- However, the *mekhoqeq* also came to mean "staff of a legislative ruler," and could be used as a synonym for "scepter" (see [Num. 21:18](#); [Ps. 60:9](#); [Deut. 33:21](#)).

From this point on, these two images (scepter and royal staff) become standard biblical metaphors to describe the future seed from the line of Yehudah who will arise to redeem Israel and the nations (see [Isa. 11:1-11](#); [Ps. 2](#) or [72](#), etc.).

"The Scepter/Rod Will Not Depart Unto/Until ..."

The Hebrew phrase in [Genesis 49:10](#) poses an interpretive challenge, and it's important to remember that the most ancient forms of the Hebrew Bible were written on scrolls without punctuation of any kind. The division of words into phrases, sentences, and paragraphs was passed on as an oral reading tradition and was subject to change. This means that sometimes the traditional sentence and phrase divisions are debatable, or we can

see that even in ancient times there were debates about how exactly to divide a sentence. Genesis 49:10 is one of those texts, and it just so happens that the meaning of an important messianic prophecy hangs in the balance.

The Hebrew text of Genesis 49:10 reads hyper-literally as follows.

Genesis 49:10 Instructor's Translation

1^a it will not depart, the rod, from Yehudah,

1^b nor the ruler-staff from between his feet

unto

2^a because he will come to whom it belongs,

2^b and to him will be the obedience of the nations

The key interpretive question is about the role of the word “unto” (Heb. *ad* / עד) in the sentence. It could be the last word of the poetic lines 1a-b (option 1), or it could be the opening word of the poetic lines 2a-b (option 2). The two options yield Hebrew sentences that are equally possible.

Option 1	Gen. 49:10 Hyper-literal 1^a it will not depart, the rod, from Yehudah, 1^b nor the ruler-staff from between his feet 2^a unto because (= “until”) he will come to whom it belongs, 2^b and to him will be the obedience of the nations 1^a לא יסור שבט מיהודה 1^b ומחקק מבין רגליו 2^a עד כי יבא שילה 2^b ולו יקהת עמים	This is reflected in nearly all of our modern translations
Option 2	Gen. 49:10 Hyper-literal 1^a it will not depart, the rod, from Yehudah, 1^b nor the ruler-staff from between his feet unto (= unto forever, i.e., “ever”) 2^a because he will come to whom it belongs, 2^b and to him will be the obedience of the nations	This interpretation is evident in ancient Jewish tradition (Targum Onqelos, Genesis Rabbah, many medieval Jewish commentators)
<i>Modern and Jewish Translations of Genesis 49:10. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>		

1a לא יסור שבט מיהודה
1b ומחקק מבין רגליו עד
2a כי יבא שילה
2b ולו יקחת עמים

Modern and Jewish Translations of Genesis 49:10. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

There are many grammatical parallels in biblical Hebrew to the phrase for option 2 (see the long list in Richard Steiner, “Four Inner-Biblical Interpretations of Gen. 49:10”, *Journal of Biblical Literature*), but there are very few parallels for option 1, and none of those occur in Hebrew poetry.

In order to make progress on this question, we need to focus on another challenge in this text, and that is the meaning of the word “rod/scepter.”

The Rod of Punishment, Power, or Both?

Recall from the above discussion that the word “rod” (Heb. *shevet*) can refer to a royal rod that symbolizes (1) power or (2) royal power used to bring judgment.

When we combine both possible meanings for “rod” with option 2 above, an interesting interpretation emerges.

1. Meaning 1: Negative

- “the rod (of God’s punishing justice) will not depart from Yehudah ever, for he will come, the one to whom that rod (of royal rule) truly belongs”

2. Meaning 2: Positive

- “the rod (of royal rule) will not depart from Yehudah ever, for he will come, the one to whom that rod (of royal rule) truly belongs”

Meaning 2 is what underlies the repeated promise in the Prophets, of an eternal kingdom that will come from the line of David (see [Isa. 9:1-7](#) or [11:1-11](#)).

Meaning 1 is the clear meaning that Nathan the prophet saw in these words when he reflected them back to David on two occasions. The first occasion is in a promise found in [2 Samuel 7](#).

2 Samuel 7:12-16 NASB*

¹² When your days are complete and you lie down with your fathers,
I will raise up your seed after you,
who will come out from you,
and I will establish his kingdom.

¹³ He shall build a house for my name,

and I will establish the throne of his kingdom unto forever (עד עולם).

¹⁴ I will be a father to him and he will be a son to me;
when he commits iniquity I will correct him,
with a human rod (שבט),
and with the strokes of the sons of humanity,

¹⁵ but my lovingkindness will not depart from him (לא יסור מ-),
as I made it depart (הסרתי) from Saul,
whom I made to depart (הסרתי) from before you.

¹⁶ Your house and your kingdom shall endure before me unto forever (עד עולם);
your throne shall be established unto forever (עד עולם).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Nathan's promise about the future lineage of David appears to take both meanings (1) and (2) into account, and sees both as possible and inevitable. David's descendants will undergo a long period of (1) divine judgment under the rod of punishment as a result of their moral failings. But the covenant failure of David's descendants will not overrule God's promise to raise up a royal deliverer from his line, and so God's loyal-love will not depart from David until there comes a future seed to whom that rule right belongs.

The second occasion is found in 2 Samuel 12, which is a judgment oracle after David's adultery and murder of Bathsheba's husband.

2 Samuel 12:9-10 NASB*

⁹ Why have you despised the word of the LORD by doing bad in his eyes?
You have struck down Uriah the Hittite with the sword,
and you have taken his wife to be your wife,
and you have murdered him with the sword of the sons of Ammon.

¹⁰ And now, the sword will not depart from (לא יסור מ-) your house, unto forever (עד עולם),
because you have despised me and have taken the wife of Uriah the Hittite to be your wife.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Here we find the permanent word of divine judgment on David's house because of his adultery and murder. In place of the "rod of punishing justice" we now have "the sword," which matches the heinous "sword of the sons of Ammon" that David orchestrated to murder Uriah.

For this interpretation, see Richard Steiner (2013), "Four Inner-Biblical Interpretations of Genesis 49:10," *Journal of Biblical Literature*, vol. 132, p. 33-60, especially p. 46-48.

"The One to Whom it Belongs" a.k.a. "Shiloh"

The phrase that appears in Genesis 49:10 is capable of multiple meanings, and it appears that all of them are not just possible, but intended by Yaaqov as an evocative and dense statement.

Literal Meaning

“unto when there comes *sh-loh* (שִׁילָה)”

Possible Meaning 1

shay-loh (שֵׁי לָהּ) = “an offering of tribute to him”

Meaning: The status of ruler will belong to Yehudah, up to the time when a ruler arrives to whom offerings of tribute will come, because the nations will offer obedience to him.

- This seems to be the meaning that is drawn upon by the poet of Psalm 72, who depicts the future messianic king as receiving tribute gifts from the nations (see Ps. 72:8-11, also Isa. 60:6-7 and Zeph. 3:9-10).

Psalm 72:8-11 NASB

⁸ May he also rule from sea to sea and from the River to the ends of the earth.

⁹ Let the nomads of the desert bow before him, and his enemies lick the dust.

¹⁰ **Let the kings of Tarshish and of the islands bring presents;
the kings of Sheba and Seba offer gifts.**

¹¹ And let all kings bow down before him, all nations serve him.

This is the interpretation held in most ancient Rabbinic literature (see *Genesis Rabbah* on Gen. 49:10, and *Yalkut Shimoni*), and it has become the majority view among modern commentators (for a survey of scholars who hold this view, see Richard Steiner (2010), “Poetic Forms in the Masoretic Vocalization of Three Difficult Phrases in Jacob's Blessing,” *Journal of Biblical Literature* vol. 129, p. 219-226).

Possible Meaning 2

shiloh (שִׁילָה) = “Shiloh” (a place name)

Meaning: The status of ruler will belong to Yehudah, up to the time when an event takes place at Shiloh that will change the balance of leadership among the tribes.

- Shiloh was a tent shrine that housed the ark of the covenant in the days of Samuel and the early monarchy (see 1 Sam. 1-2, 7). In this interpretation, this line is a forward reference to the division of the Israelite kingdoms after Solomon's reign, when Ahijah the prophet from Shiloh announced that Yehudah would become a lone kingdom and the northern tribes would secede (see 1 Kgs. 11:29-40).

Possible Meaning 3

shey-loh (שֵׁי לָהּ) = “what belongs to him”

Meaning: The status of ruler will belong to Yehudah, up to the time when an individual comes to whom that royal status truly belongs, and when that ruler comes, the nations will offer their obedience to him.

- This seems to be the meaning that Ezekiel drew from this poem, as he depicts the royal line of David as subject to ruin and divine judgment (see Ezek. 21:21-26), “until he comes, the one to whom justice rightfully belongs, and I will give it to that one” (Ezek. 21:27).

A Ruler Over the Family of Abraham and the Nations

Notice how Genesis 49:8-12 focuses on the dual nature of this future king's rule. It will encompass the tribal brothers of Yehudah, that is, the tribes of Israel. But the nations ("the peoples") will also come under this king's rule as well.

In this pairing, we watch the fulfillment of God's promise to Abraham back in Genesis 12:1-3 that he would provide a blessing for Abraham's family that would flow out and become a blessing for all the nations.

Eden Garden Imagery

The images in Genesis 49:11-12 are dense and riddle-like, but the overwhelming presence of garden imagery is undeniable.

- "binding a donkey to vine" = Productive vines are both precious and fragile, and parking one's donkey next to one would be unthinkable! The animal would devour and stomp all over the fragile vine. But, in an Eden-like world, where vines are plentiful and where "every man sat under his own vine and fig tree" (see 1 Kgs. 4:25; Mic. 4:4; Zech. 3:10), you can park your donkey by a vine and not even think about it. There's another one a few feet away!
- "washing his clothing in wine" = This is a dual image of (1) abundance, because wine was precious and wash-water is definitely not! But in an Eden world, the wash-water is wine, the streets are gold, and the city walls are made of precious stones (alluding to Rev. 21:18-21). This is also an image of (2) royalty: If you dye clothing in wine, it becomes purple, an ancient symbol of royalty (along with blue and red).
- "His eyes sparkle from wine, and teeth are white from milk" = These are also riddle-images of abundance. Sparkling eyes from wine can indicate intoxication (the same word is used in Prov. 23:29), which, in a celebration atmosphere, can be positive and associated with a celebration of God's abundant blessings (see Ps. 104:15). Abundant milk and white teeth are also signs of abundance, signaling large cow herds and healthy teeth.

Reflection Question

What are the possible meanings of the promise that "the scepter will not depart from Yehudah" in Genesis 49:10?